Big Fish: A Novel of Mythical Proportions

By Daniel Wallace

(My Father's Death: Take 4) One of our last car trips, near the end of my father's life as a man, we stopped by a river. After a couple of minutes my father took off his shoes and his socks and placed his feet in the clear-running water. Then he closed his eyes and smiled.

DAD: This reminds me . . . .

And then he stopped and thought some more. I guessed he was thinking of some joke to tell, because he always had some joke to tell. Or he might tell me a story that would celebrate his adventurous and heroic life. Does it remind him of the duck in the hardware store? The horse in the bar? The boy who was knee-high to a grasshopper? Did it remind him of the dinosaur egg he found one day, then lost, or the country he once ruled for the better part of a week?

DAD: This reminds me of when I was a boy.

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I looked at this old man, my old man with his old white feet in this clear-running stream, and I thought of him suddenly, and simply, as a boy. I'd never done that before. And these images--the now and then of my father--converged, and at that moment he turned into a weird creature, wild, concurrently young and old, dying and newborn . . My father became a myth.

INTRODUCTION

In Big Fish, William Bloom has never really known his father, a charming, globe-trotting salesman with a joke for every occasion. Now Edward Bloom, dying, comes home to Alabama, and his son hopes for a connection, before he dies. This selection is the final chapter in Edward Bloom's mythical life. "Mythical" I say because William has created a life for his father from his own imagination – a life of mythical proportions. Is the story of Edward's death true, though difficult to believe, or is it the final chapter of a life so incredible that one MUST believe? I'll leave that to you to decide.

My Father's Death: Take 4 from Big Fish by Daniel Wallace.

My father was dying. Sheltered inside an oxygen tent at Jefferson Memorial Hospital, his small, emaciated body seemed bleak and translucent, a kind of ghost already.

The doctors were all very grave, even hopeless. Dr. Bennett, our old family doctor, synthesized the details of ongoing reports; he would give us the Big Picture. Dr. Bennett had an old, tired face. The rings beneath his eyes were like dark brown ruts in a road. He had been our doctor for years. But he was a good doctor, and we trusted him.

DR. BENNETT: Mr. Bloom may not make it out of this one. There are a couple of things we want to try—we're not giving up, not by a long shot. But I've seen this sort of thing before. It's sad, I—I've known Edward Bloom for a quarter of a century. I don't feel like his doctor anymore. I feel like a friend, you know? A friend who wishes he could do something. But without the machines . . . " *(Shakes head sadly)*

I turned and wandered away while he continued to talk to my mother. I went to my father's room and sat in the chair beside his bed. I sat there and waited—for what I don't know—and stared at those marvelous machines. This wasn't life, of course. This was life support. This was what the medical world had fashioned to take the place of Purgatory. I could see how many breaths he was taking by

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looking at a monitor. I could see what his frenetic heart was up to. And there were a couple of wavy lines and numbers I wasn't sure about at all, but I kept an eye on them as well. In fact, after a while it was the machines I was looking at, not my father at all. They had become him. They were telling me his story.

Which reminds me of this joke. I'll always remember his jokes, but this one especially I will remember. It's a family heirloom. It's one I tell myself still, out loud and alone, the way he told it to me, I say, There's this man. There's this man, and he's a poor man but he needs a new suit. This man needs a new suit, but he can't afford to buy one, he can't afford to buy one until he passes a store where there's this suit on sale, and it's priced just right, this beautiful dark blue suit with pinstripes—and so he buys it. Just like that he buys it and wears it right out of the store with a matching tie and everything, but the joke here is—and I guess I should've mentioned this earlier—the joke is it doesn't fit. This suit doesn't fit him at all. It's simply way too big. But it's his suit, right? It's his suit. So to make it look good he has to place an elbow against his side like this, and his other arm out sort of like this, and he has to walk

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without moving one of his legs so that the cuffs will appear even, this tiny man in this huge suit—which, as I said, he walks out wearing, walks out into the street wearing. And he thinks to himself, What a nice suit I have! and walks with his arms just so—my father would make his arms just so—and dragging one leg behind with this smile on his face like an idiot because of this great buy he's just made—a suit! on sale!—when he passes two old women on the avenue there. They watch him pass, and one of them shakes her head and says to the other, "What a poor, poor man!" And the other woman says, "Yes—but what a nice suit!"

Which is the end of this joke.

But I can't tell it like my father did. I can't drag my leg the way he did it, and so even though this is the funniest joke I have ever heard in my life, I don't laugh. I can't. Even when the lady says "Yes—but what a nice suit!" I'm not laughing. I'm not laughing at all.

I'm doing the other thing.

I suppose this is what roused him, brought him back to the world for a bit, thinking that if there was anytime I needed a joke, now was the time. God, he really cracked me up.

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DAD: Some water. Get me some water.

Some water, he says! Oh and it's his voice all right, it's his voice, deep and booming, caring and gentle. And I get him some water, and he calls me over, to his bed, his only son, me, his only child, and he pats a place on the edge of the bed where I'm to sit, right? So I sit. There's no time for hellos and how are yous and we both know it. And he says, after taking a sip of water from the little plastic cup, "Son," he says, "I'm worried."

And he says it in this real shaky voice so I know, don't ask me how but I know that, machines or not, this will be the last time I ever see him alive. Tomorrow, he'll be dead.

SON: What is it you're worried about, Dad? The hereafter?

DAD: No, dummy. I'm worried about you. You're an idiot. You couldn't get yourself arrested without me along to help.

But I don't take it personal: he's trying to be funny. He's trying to be funny and this is the best he can do! Now I know he's a goner.

SON: Don't worry about me, Dad. I'll be okay. I'll be fine.

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DAD: I'm a father, I can't help it. A father worries. I am a father and as a father I've tried to teach you a thing or two. I really did try. Maybe I wasn't around so much, but when I was, I tried to teach. So what I want to know is—you think I did a good job? *(Beat)* Wait! Don't answer that! *(trying to smile, but it doesn't quite work)* Oh, go on, then. Just tell me before I die. Tell me what it is I've taught you. Tell me everything it is I've taught you about life so I can go ahead and die and so I won't have to worry so much. Just . . . just go ahead and say it.

I look into his gray-blue dying eyes. We're staring at each other, showing each other our last looks, the faces we'll take with us into eternity, and I'm thinking how I wish I knew him better, how I wish we'd had a life together, wishing my father wasn't such a complete and utter mystery to me, and I say, "There's this man," I say. "There's this man, and he's a poor man, but he needs a suit, and—"

And he smiled. Then he cast his gaze around the room, and he winked at me. He winked!

DAD: *(in a hoarse whisper)* Let's get out of here.

SON: Out of here? Dad, you're in no condition . . .

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DAD: There's a fold-up wheelchair in the bathroom. Wrap a blanket around me. As soon as we get off this hall, we'll be in the clear. But we don't have much time. Hurry, son!

I did as he asked, I don't know why. I wrapped him with a pale brown blanket, covering his head like a monk's habit. I lifted him, with a disturbing ease, from his bed and into the chair. I had no gotten no stronger in the last few months, but he had become considerably smaller.

I opened the door to his room and peeked out into the hallway. I saw Mom at the nurse's desk with Dr. Bennett, wiping her eyes with a tissue and nodding. I pushed my father in the opposite direction. I dared not even look behind me to see if they had spied us. I just pushed him fast, hoping for the best, and when we came to a corner went around it. Only then did I allow myself a backward view. Nobody. So far, so good.

SON: *(Breathlessly)* So. Where are we going?"

DAD: The elevators. The elevator to the lobby to wherever you parked your car. Take me there. Now. We don't have much time.

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The elevator came and I pushed him on. The door closed behind us, and when they opened again I wheeled him out of there with a daredevil's panache, past a host of doctors in green and white, past nurses holding charts giving me sidelong glances. Everybody in the lobby paused and stared at us, knowing this wasn't right somehow, but by then I was traveling at such speed that no one had the time to think to stop us. They simply looked at us as though they had seen something odd—and they had, too, odder than they knew. And then we were gone.

DAD: Good job. Still need to hurry, though, Will. I need some water. I need some water bad.

SON: I have some in the car -- A thermos full.

DAD: *(laughing)* More than that.

When we got to the car I lifted him out of the wheelchair and placed him in the front seat. I folded the wheelchair and threw it in the back.

DAD: We won't be needing that. *(laughing)* Not where we're going.

But he didn't tell me where we were going, not at first. I simply drove away from everything I knew: the hospital, his old office, home.

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DAD: That water, William?"

It was beside me on the seat. I opened the top and passed it to him. One shaky, scaly hand appeared from beneath the folds and took it from me. But instead of drinking it, he poured it all over himself. The blanket was soaked.

DAD: Ahh . . . That's the ticket.

Still, he didn't take the blanket off.

DAD: Go north on Highway 1. There's a place there. There's a river. A place by the river.

I took the car down a series of streets, through the city and the surrounding suburbs, where the sun was rising over the roofs and treetops, until finally we broke into the deep, green, beautiful country.

SON: How far now?

DAD: Just a couple more miles, I think. I hope. I don't feel so good.

SON: What's there?

But for an answer all I got was a shivering inside the damp blanket, and a gurgling, groaning sound, as if he were in deep pain.

SON: Are you okay?

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DAD: Been better. I feel like that guy . . .

Who walks into the bar with a frog on his head, with a bird on his shoulder, with a kangaroo at his side and the bartender says, "Hey, we don't get that many kangaroos in here," and the kangaroo says, "Yeah, and at these prices you're not likely to get many more!" And then he said, suddenly almost yelling,

DAD: Here!

And I pulled off the road. There was your old oak tree with the roots spreading out through the dark and mossy soil. And there was your river, running clear the way you didn't think rivers ran anymore, moving fast around stones the size of a small car, making little rapids, running as clear as the air, as blue as the sky, as white as a cloud. I don't know how he saw it from beneath the blanket.

"Carry me," he said, or so it sounded, his voice so weak now I was doing my share of interpreting as I listened. He said, Carry me and You don't know how I appreciate what you're doing and When you see your mother, tell her—tell her I said good-bye. And so I carried him out of the car and down the mossy bank to the river and stood there before it, holding my father in my arms. And I knew what I was

4NG Fanatics

supposed to do then but I couldn't do it. I just stood there, holding his body shrouded in a blanket on the banks of this river, until he told me, You might want to look away now and then Please, and all of a sudden my arms were full of the most fantastic life, frenetic, impossible to hold on to even if I'd wanted to, and I wanted to. But then all I was holding was the blanket, because my father had jumped into the river. And that's when I discovered that my father hadn't been dying after all. He was just changing, transforming himself into something new and different to carry his life forward in.

All this time, my father was becoming a fish.

I saw him dart this way and that, a silvery, brilliant, shining life, and disappear into the darkness of the deep water where the big fish go, and I haven't seen him since—though others have. Already I've heard stories, of lives saved and wishes granted, of children carried for miles on his back, of anglers mischievously dumped from their vessels and emptied into various oceans and streams from Beaufort to Hyannis by the biggest fish they've ever seen, and they tell their stories to anybody who will listen.

But no one believes them. No one believes a word.

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AWARD HISTORY

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